On 16 November – arguing vigorously that his life expectancy was estimated to be three to six months, while the legal process was forecast to take at least two years, Honecker's lawyers questioned whether it was humane to try a dying man. The following day, proceedings were edging toward an ignominious collapse when Erich Mielke was withdrawn from the trial as his memory floundered about dates, people and places. The next morning, another hearing was adjourned after Honecker was quoted as saying: 'I cannot take any more.' A doctor said he was suffering from an irregular heartbeat and high blood pressure. Again, Nicolas Becker filed a motion to throw out the whole case. 'A man is in danger of being tried to death by typically German thoroughness and implacability,' he said. 'The point of continuing this trial can only be to torment the defendant.' However, the judge was in no hurry to end proceedings and, finally, on Thursday, 3 December, Honecker prepared to deliver the speech he had spent months drafting in prison.

'I don't feel any pain or weakness,' he noted in his diary before entering room 700 of Moabit criminal court. After being called over to the dock, Honecker described his trial as a travesty of justice. 'It is political theatre,' he said, speaking in a soft but authoritative voice. Furthermore, looking directly at the judges, he said the Berlin Wall had prevented an international confrontation. 'Not building the Wall would have meant the risk of a third world war.' With an eye to the history books, he stood by the fact that the 'decision of 1961 was correct and remained correct'.

As his seventy-minute statement continued, he navigated into murkier waters by noting, 'the people being tried today were yesterday welcomed as honoured guests of the state. Either the politicians from West Germany voluntarily and eagerly greeted a murderer, or they did not consider him guilty of murder.' For his closing statement, Honecker crafted these words:

I am not going to lend this accusation and this court procedure the appearance of legality by defending myself against the evidently unfounded accusation of manslaughter. A defence is also superfluous because I will not live to hear your verdict. The punishment which you evidently have in mind